

1)

Please select a passage from any of the texts we have read up until this point in the semester (3-5-26). Please quote the passage in its entirety. Please explicate the passage, that is, please explain in your own words what the passage means, how it relates to the rest of the text, and what the passage contributes to the overarching structure of the text.

The text passage I am choosing to write on is in Spinoza's "Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect" and is paragraph 19 which is on page 237:

"If I examine them carefully, they can all be classified under four headings.

1. There is the perception we have from hearsay, or from some sign conventionally agreed upon.
2. There is the perception we have from casual experience; that is, experience that is not determined by intellect, but is so called because it chances thus to occur, and we have experienced nothing else that contradicts it, so that it remains in our minds unchallenged.
3. There is the perception we have when the essence of a thing is inferred from another thing, but not adequately. This happens either when we infer a cause from some effect or when an inference is made from some universal which is made from some universal which is always accompanied by some property
4. Finally, there is the perception we have when a thing is perceived through its essence alone, or through knowledge of its proximate cause."¹

This passage is quite essential to Spinoza's argument as it is Spinoza's way of categorizing how we acquire knowledge. This acts as an important foundation for Spinoza as he argues that all acquisitions of knowledge fall into these categories. The first of which is his category of hearsay. This category is for all perceptions whose origin is not one's own. This category goes beyond simply spoken words but also includes "some sign conventionally agreed upon"². The key for this category is that the knower has no direct means to verify the claim other than the words of others. In other words, the knower accepts this knowledge as true because it was told to them. The second category pertains to the forms of knowledge gained through lived or observed experience. An example of this given by Spinoza is that he knows that he will eventually "die"³ because he has seen others like him who

¹Spinoza, Benedictus de, Samuel Shirley, and Seymour Feldman. *The Ethics ; Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect ; Selected Letters*. 2nd ed. Indianapolis: Hackett Pub. Co., 1992. 237

²Spinoza. *The Ethics*. 237

³Spinoza. *The Ethics*. 237

have “died”⁴. Most importantly here, Spinoza notes that these forms of perceptions are only deemed as true simply because “we have experienced nothing else that contradicts it”⁵. Thus, this is the form of knowledge which attempts to create universals through a set of consistent particulars. The third category is in reference to things learned through other things. Specifically Spinoza separates this group into 2 sub categories, cause and effect, and universals accomponied by a property. The example of inference through cause and effect given by Spinoza is simply that we only feel the sensations from a singular body (our own) suggesting some sort of union between our soul and body. The example of inference through universals and properties given in the text is that since vision has the property of making things appear smaller as their distance increase can be combined with the knowledge that the sun is far away to deduce that the sun is actually much larger than it appears. This sort of knowledge inference reminds me of derived axioms as they combine known axioms through universal logical tautologies to produce these new derived axioms. Lastly the fourth category pertains to things whose perception is from the essence of the thing alone.

Once Spinoza has fully fleshed out these categories, he uses them as the foundation for why it is only the 4th category (perception through an essence) is the only form of perception which can be used to find the “true good”⁶. For starters, it is easiest to see that the first two categories are the most prone to error. The perceptions from hearsay can be wrong simply from the appeal to authority fallacy or similarly just from common misconceptions being passed down through generations such as the Earth being flat or sun revolving around the Earth. The second category leaves room for uncertainty since lived experience and particulars is not necessarily strong enough / sufficient to produce universals. Additionally, Spinoza notes that this form of perception creates knowledge which is an observable surface level property of things rather than the true essence of the things itself. This knowledge can help a knower understand *what* is to happen but not *why* it happens. The third category may not be as prone to error as the former categories, but Spinoza still believes that one cannot hope to grasp the essence of the thing itself through inference alone. This leaves us with the final form of perception which Spinoza believes that it is only mode in which perception is able to “comprehends the adequate essence of the thing, and is without danger of error”⁷.

2)

Please give a philosophical assessment of the significance or interest of the passage.

⁴Spinoza. The Ethics. 237

⁵Spinoza. The Ethics. 237

⁶Spinoza. The Ethics. 233

⁷Spinoza. The Ethics. 239

This passage lays out the very foundation for the categories of modes of perception. From this, Spinoza argues that it is only the 4th category, perception of a thing through its essence, is the only mode of perception which leads to adequate and error free knowledge, essentially for finding what the “true good”⁸ is. However, it is also important to realize that these categories were introduced to us by Spinoza in a sorted order ascending from weakest to strongest in obtaining the true essence of things. The first category of hearsay gives the knower no essence of the object. Next the second category only gives accidents, the surface level properties of things. The third, Spinoza still argues that this mode may result in truths but not necessarily the essence of the thing itself. Still, a fundamental flaw of this passage is that Spinoza asserts that the fourth mode is the only mode for obtaining the essence of things as it is the only mode to perceive the essence of the thing itself, yet this mode is perhaps the least clear. This mode still remains a goal, as in a knower should strive to perceive the essence of the very thing itself, yet Spinoza does not provide any way in which a knower could possibly hope to perceive the essence of the things. Through these assertions, it is clear that Spinoza is undermining the lived experiences and sense derived knowledge compared to the direct perception of the essence. This reminds me of Descartes who similarly undermined the knowledge acquired through the senses but had entirely different reasoning for undermining the senses. Descartes undermined the senses because there was room for doubt. Spinoza seemingly is shifting the focus of philosophy from collecting facts about the world but understanding the essence of the things themselves. However, I still remain skeptical about Spinoza’s view that the only adequate way of learning about the essence of things is to directly perceive the essence of the thing itself. Perhaps I am more onboard with Descartes ideas of creating a concrete foundation free of doubt in order to derive further truths, which is a direct contradiction to Spinoza’s view that the only way to perceive the essence of things is to perceive the essence of the thing itself. As a brief and over simplified counterexample against Spinoza’s perspective, Godel’s incompleteness theorem which proves that any formal system of axioms cannot be both complete and consistent. This of course used a variety of derivations to prove this simple statement, which one could argue pertains the essence of derivations and formal systems themselves. Additionally, I find it hard to reconcile with perceiving the essence of things themselves without using the essence of others. Even in Spinoza’s examples of addition and parallel lines, these are both subcategories of arithmetic and geometry respectively and they’re essences are necessary (but not sufficient) to understand the essence of their umbrella categories. Thus, while this passage acts as the foundational work to find the “true good”⁹ (which might be seen as ironic), it is important to note that Spinoza is arguing for a different but necessary form of knowing and perception. Spinoza’s work may have took inspiration from Aristotle’s intellectual virtues, especially with notions

⁸Spinoza. The Ethics. 233

⁹Spinoza. The Ethics. 233

of essences of things and large amounts of categorizing the forms of knowledge; Spinoza's vision for the modes of perception vastly differ from his predecessors and act as a strong foundation for future philosophical work.